M. Cecilia Ramírez-Michelena

Applied Economist | Policy Evaluation & Research Projects
Barcelona, open to relocation | Spanish & Uruguayan citizen

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Professional Summary

Applied economist and final-stage Ph.D. candidate in Economics with experience developing and delivering applied research projects across Spain, the United States, and Uruguay. My work combines causal inference, randomized evaluations, and large administrative and survey datasets with field implementation, institutional coordination, and communication of findings to academic and policy audiences. I have experience taking projects from the research question and empirical design through funding, implementation, analysis, and dissemination, including work with public institutions, schools, field teams, and multidisciplinary partners. My research focuses on education, labor markets, gender inequality, and social policy, with a particular interest in producing rigorous evidence that can inform policy design and evaluation.

Core Competencies: Applied microeconomics and policy evaluation; causal inference and randomized evaluations; administrative microdata; research project design and implementation; grant applications; stakeholder coordination; research and policy writing.

Professional Experience

Institut d'Economia de Barcelona, Universitat de Barcelona 10/2021 – Present
Predoctoral Researcher *Barcelona, Spain*

- Conduct applied research in education and labor economics using linked administrative microdata, survey data, and causal inference methods. Current projects examine gender gaps in STEM pathways in Catalonia, child penalties within Spanish couples, and the educational effects of rural school electrification in Uruguay.
- Building on findings from my research on STEM choices in Catalonia, conceived and proposed a school-based randomized information intervention and discrete choice experiment for secondary-school students, now being developed with my co-authors. Independently prepared the successful EUR 10,000 funding application to the Women and Science Programme at Paris Dauphine–PSL and lead preparation for implementation (expected in December 2026), including treatment and survey design, school engagement, ethics and data-protection approvals, preregistration, fieldwork planning, and budget management.

Education Policy Analytics Lab, College of Education, University of Washington 09/2018 – 09/2019
Research Associate *Seattle, United States*

- Worked in a research-practice partnership with Seattle Public Schools, the largest K–12 public school district in Washington State, analyzing administrative data on teacher effectiveness, absenteeism, staffing, and retention, particularly in schools serving disadvantaged students.
- Worked with senior district leadership, analysts, school administrators, program managers, and teachers' union representatives to turn operational concerns into empirical questions that could be addressed with available data, incorporate institutional knowledge into the analysis, and communicate findings and their limitations through internal reports, technical notes, and presentations for district decision-makers.

Center for Research in Applied Economics, Universidad de Montevideo 06/2015 – 07/2018
Research Assistant and Field Leader *Montevideo, Uruguay*

- Helped design two randomized evaluations and led their field implementation. One examined access to social benefits among more than 300 informal street workers. The other evaluated a digital inclusion program for more than 120 older adults in public long-term care. Worked on intervention and survey design, data-quality monitoring, quantitative analysis, and research outputs; co-author of a working paper and a peer-reviewed publication.
- Coordinated implementation across public agencies, social workers, hospital staff, volunteers, and research teams; recruited, trained, and supervised field personnel; identified implementation bottlenecks and adapted field procedures while preserving the evaluation design and data quality.

Education

Universitat de Barcelona, Barcelona, Spain
Ph.D. candidate in Economics — Thesis submitted, defense expected January 2027
Dissertation: *Unequal Starts, Unequal Choices, Unequal Returns: Essays on Human Capital and Inequality.*
Supervisors: Profs. Lídia Farré and Andreu Arenas.

Visiting doctoral student, **Teachers College, Columbia University**, New York, US — Fall 2026
Visiting doctoral student, **Paris School of Economics**, Paris, France — Summer 2026

University of Washington, Seattle, United States
M.Ed. in Educational Foundations, Leadership, and Policy Studies — 2021
M.A. in Economics — 2021

Universidad de Montevideo, Montevideo, Uruguay
M.A. in Economics — 2020
B.A. in Economics — 2016
B.A. in Management and Business Administration — 2016

Selected Grants & Fellowships

Fellowships	Doctoral Fellowship, Fundación Ramón Areces (2023–2027). Fulbright Scholarship for Graduate Studies, Fulbright Commission (2018–2020).
Research Grants	Research grant, Women and Science Chair, Université Paris Dauphine–PSL, €10,000 (2025)

Technical Skills & Languages

Methods & Data	Advanced causal inference methods; randomized controlled trials; survey design. Linked administrative records; survey, experimental, and longitudinal microdata.
Research & Project Management	Research design, competitive grant proposals, budget management, and field implementation. Recruitment and supervision of field teams, data quality monitoring, and coordination with public agencies.
Research Outputs	Policy briefs and technical notes for public-sector decision-makers, analytical reports, and academic papers. Presentations for policy and academic audiences.
Software	Stata (advanced); R and Python (working knowledge); LaTeX; Git/GitHub.
Languages	Spanish, native; English, fluent; Catalan, intermediate.

Selected Research

- Power to Attend: School Electrification and Educational Gains in Rural Uruguay. With M. Blanco and N. D'Agosti. Working Paper, October 2026. Presented at the Econ and Education PhD Colloquium (Columbia University), 2026; and the European Association of Labour Economists (EALE), 2024.
- Math Comparative Advantage and the Gender Gap in STEM: From Upper-Secondary Tracks to University Degrees. With A. Arenas and L. Farré. Working Paper, November 2026. Presented at the BRIDGE Economics of Education Workshop (KU Leuven) and the SEHO Annual Meeting, 2025.
- Who Gives Way? The Child Penalty within Spanish Couples. Working Paper, October 2026.
- Connecting Informal Workers to the State: A Field Experiment in the Streets of Montevideo. With A. Cid, J.M. Cabrera, and M. Blanco. Working Paper, October 2026.
- Tablets for Deeply Disadvantaged Older Adults: Challenges in Long-term Care Facilities. With A. Cid, R. Sotelo, and M. Leguisamo. *International Journal of Human-Computer Studies* (2020).

Student Supervision & Teaching Experience

Universitat de Barcelona – Instructor and B.A. Thesis Advisor, Department of Economics. Spring 2024, 2025, 2026
IFSA Barcelona – Lecturer. Winter 2026
University of Washington – Instructor, Department of Spanish and Portuguese Studies. Fall 2020 – Spring 2021
Universidad de Montevideo – Teaching Assistant, Department of Economics. Fall 2014 – Spring 2015